MY SOUL WAS SEIZED WITH EXCEEDING SORROW

When Badauni would later write his covert, critical, and despairing biography of Akbar, the *Muntakhabh al-Tawarikh*, he would place considerable blame for Akbar's un-Islamic practices on Hindus, whom Badauni roundly and unapologetically detested, including Akbar's Hindu wives. '[Akbar] had introduced a whole host of the daughters of the eminent Hindu rajas into his haram,' he noted darkly, 'and they had influenced his mind against the eating of beef and garlic and onions, and association with people who wore beards— and such things he then avoided and still does avoid.' However, as a very young man, Akbar was considered a rather orthodox Islamic Padshah, performing namaaz five times a day, and he believed his Hindu subjects to be sadly deluded. Referring to that period in his life, Akbar would later write regretfully: 'Formerly I persecuted men into conformity with my faith and deemed it Islam' (he was referring here to a few incidents of forced conversion). 'As I grew in knowledge, I was overwhelmed with shame.' That one of the sources of knowledge that Akbar referred to were his Hindu wives is clear from the subtle shift in policies implemented around the time he first married Hindu women.

One of the first such measures, attributed by Shirazi to one of Akbar's Hindu wives, was the prohibiting of enslavement of prisoners of war, and indeed an order to end the slave trade altogether. Abu'l Fazl was honest when he wrote about imperial soldiers 'making captive the women, children and kinsmen of the opposing soldier and selling them, or keeping them as slaves'. According to Shirazi, some two lakh persons were captured every year in the Mughal Empire and exported as slaves. Now, though Akbar still believed that 'killing, imprisoning and whipping' rebellious persons was necessary, any attempt to torture their innocent women and children was deemed abhorrent. 'If husbands take to wretchedness, what fault is it of their wives?' Akbar is noted as having said, 'if fathers tread the path of rebellion, what sin is it of their children?'

On one occasion, Akbar had gone hunting in the vicinity of Mathura with a small group of his closest companions, including Mirza Aziz Koka. The men enjoyed a vigorous day of hunting, killing five lions in a single